

Board: 1

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♠

Declarer: North

Lead: ♦ A

Board: 2

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4♥

Declarer: East

Lead: ♠ 2

Board: 3

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6NT

Declarer: South

Lead: ♠ Q

Board: 4

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3♥

Declarer: West

Lead: ♦ A

Board 1

North Deals
None Vul

♠ 5 3
♥ Q 10 6 2
♦ Q 8 3
♣ K 9 7 4

♠ A J 8 6
♥ A K
♦ J 9 5
♣ A Q J 10

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 10 9 4
♥ 9 8 7 5 3
♦ A K 10 4
♣ 8

♠ K Q 7 2
♥ J 4
♦ 7 6 2
♣ 6 5 3 2

West	North	East	South
	2NT	Pass	3♣
Pass	3♠	Pass	4♠

All Pass
4♠ by North
Lead: ♦ A

not lose the ♣.

You must find West with the ♣K and you must be able to finesse three times. That means three dummy entries and they all must come from the trump suit.

Play the ♠A, then lead the ♠8 to dummy's ♠Q. Notice that you must save your ♠6. Pay attention to whether both defenders follow to both tricks. They do, and that means there is only one ♠ left out. Play a ♣ and finesse the ♣10. Now lead the ♠J to dummy's ♠K. Finesse the ♣J. Finally, lead the ♠6 to dummy's ♠7. Finesse the ♣Q. Claim the rest.

This was not an easy plan.

The first part is realizing that you need to have three entries to dummy.

The second part is figuring out that the ♠ suit could provide them.

Partner has 20-21 points, so with your 6 you belong in game. But which game?

You use Stayman convention to try to find out.
Partner responds 3♠.

You have at least 26 combined points and 8 ♠s. So you bid 4♠.

South would play 4♠.

North plays 4♠. East leads ♦A, ♦K, ♦4. West wins the third trick with ♦Q and plays a ♥.

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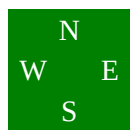
Losers: ♠ 0 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 3 : ♣ 1 : Total = 4

Since you've already lost the three ♦s you'd better

Board 2
West Deals
N-S Vul

♠ 10 7 3
♥ K J 5 4
♦ K 7
♣ A Q 10 6

♠ Q 6 5 4
♥ 9 6
♦ A Q J 9
♣ K 7 2



♠ A 8
♥ A Q 10 8 3 2
♦ 8 4
♣ J 9 4

♠ K J 9 2
♥ 7
♦ 10 6 5 3 2
♣ 8 5 3

West	North	East	South
1 ♣	Pass	1 ♥	Pass
2 ♥	Pass	4 ♥	
All Pass			
4 ♥ by East			
Lead: ♠ 2			

losers. Even if the finesse fails you still have an extra winner for the discard.

Is there a danger here? Yes. Suppose you win the first trick, pull trumps, then finesse the ♣. North might win and play a ♠ back to South's hand. And South might then lead a ♦ through dummy's ♦ K.

South is the Danger Hand. You want to keep him off the lead. His only possible entry is the ♠ suit, so all you have to do is hold up on the first trick. Win the second ♠, pull trumps as before, and finesse the ♣. North wins but cannot get to his partner's hand for the killing ♦ lead. You will discard one of your ♦ losers on dummy's fourth ♣.

You usually think of a hold-up play in a Notrump contract, trying to exhaust one defender of his partner's suit.

For this deal the hold-up serves a different purpose. It keeps one defender from ever gaining the lead.

You had to lose one ♠ in any case, so you just choose to lose it to the defender who cannot hurt you.

Notice that the Danger Hand **WAS** on lead at one point - the opening lead. If South had been clairvoyant enough to lead a ♦ the contract could have been beaten. Opening leads are important to the defense.

Don't even think of jumping to 2♥. That would show 17+ points. Instead you just bid 1♥, knowing partner is forced to bid again.

Partner does bid again, saying 2♥.

Partner's rebid promises a minimum opening bid (13-15) and four ♥s. That makes your total about 28 points and ten ♥s. So you bid game.

East plays 4♥. South leads the ♠ 2, North playing the ♠ Q.

East plays 4♥. South leads the ♠ 2, North playing the ♠ Q.

Losers: ♠ 1 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 2 : ♣ 1 : Total = 4

If the ♣ finesse works you have no ♣ loser, and as a bonus you will be able to discard one of your other

Board 3

North Deals

None Vul

♠ Q J 10 8 4

♥ 4

♦ 7 6 3

♣ K 6 4 3

♠ 7 2

♥ K Q 8 7 6 3

♦ K 9 4

♣ 8 5



♠ 9 6 5 3

♥ 10 9 5 2

♦ A 8 5

♣ 10 9

♠ A K

♥ A J

♦ Q J 10 2

♣ A Q J 7 2

West

North

East

South

2♥

Pass

2NT

Pass

3♦

Pass

6NT

All Pass

6NT by South

Lead: ♠ Q

You were probably stunned when you picked up this hand and even more stunned when partner bid.

Your biggest problem is that partner has opened with a weak bid and won't credit you with such a huge hand. So you must make sure you don't make a bid he might pass until you're ready.

For example, suppose you made a jump shift to 4♣. Would partner know what that meant? Do you know what it meant?

The best(?) bid at this point is probably 2NT. Everybody knows what that means. Partner is forced to reply, and will either rebid his suit with a minimum hand or show a "feature" if his hand is better than minimum.

Partner replies 3♦.

Trust your partner. He has shown a better-than-minimum Weak-2 bid, probably 9-11 points, and a high card in ♦s, either the ♦A or ♦K.

With your hand you don't need anything else to make a slam. You have to decide between 6♥ and 6NT. Based on your reluctance to have an opening ♣ lead go through your ♣ A Q you choose 6NT.

South plays 6NT. West leads the ♠ Q.

South plays 6NT. West leads the ♠ Q.

Winners: ♠ 2 : ♥ 6? : ♦ 0 : ♣ 1 : Total = 9

The winner list isn't as bad as it looks, once you drive out the ♦A you'll have your three extra winners in ♦s.

In fact, your only real problem is making sure you get all 6 ♥ winners. If the ♥s split 3-2 it's easy, but if they are 4-1 you cannot afford to overtake the ♥J at the second trick. Fortunately dummy has both the ♦K and the ♦9.

Win the ♠A. Play ♥A and ♥J. West shows out on the second one. Lead your ♦2 to dummy's ♦9. Either you are in dummy now to run the ♥s, or East wins the trick with the ♦A. In this case you can win his return (don't finesse if he leads a ♣), and get to dummy with the ♦K to run the ♥s.

A 4-1 split isn't as likely as a 3-2 split.

But when you can

In this case dummy had a certain entry in the ♦ suit so you take advantage of that entry.

Board 4

West Deals

Both Vul

♠ A J 4
 ♥ K Q J 10 8 6
 ♦ 8 7 3
 ♣ 6

♠ Q 6

♥ A

♦ A K J 9 6 5

♣ 9 7 5 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 7 3

♥ 5 4 3 2

♦ Q 4

♣ A K 10 8 3

♠ K 10 9 8 5 2

♥ 9 7

♦ 10 2

♣ Q J 4

West	North	East	South
1♥	2♦	2♥	2♠
Pass	Pass	3♥	
All Pass			
3♥ by West			
Lead: ♦ A			

With 11 points you would probably have bid 3♥, a limit raise, if South hadn't overcalled.

But you now doubt your ♦Q is worth 2 points so you just say 2♥.

Now North comes in with 2♠ and it is passed around to you.

With a known 9-card fit this hand is worth a 3♥ bid.

Everybody passes.

East would play 3♥.

West plays 3♥. North leads ♦A, ♦K, ♦J. South plays first the ♦10, then ♦2.

West plays 3♥. North leads ♦A, ♦K, ♦J. South plays first the ♦10, then ♦2.

Losers: ♠ 2 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 3 : ♣ 0 : Total = 6

Although there are two ♠ losers in your hand, one can either be ruffed in dummy or discarded on a high ♣. So you really only have one loser too many.

You should realize that if you ruff this ♦ with one of dummy's teensy ♥s it will be over-ruffed. South did signal a doubleton. The loss of the teensy ♥ doesn't worry you, you have plenty of them. But the loss of the opportunity to dump a loser should worry you a lot.

So don't ruff at all. Discard a ♠. Now you can ruff your other ♠ loser in dummy.

Be ever watchful for situations where you may be over-ruffed.

Often, like in this deal, you can discard a loser instead.